Thus, unlike during his 1949 visit, on his 1956 trip Nehru was not as bashful about making India's needs known. House Foreign Affairs Committee chairman James Prioleau Richards (D-SC) and members Adair (R-IN) and Armistead I. Selden Jr. (D-AL), as well as Appropriations Committee members in the House (Henderson L. Lanham, D-GA) and Senate (Allen J. Ellender, D-LA) had questioned why India did not deign to ask for or acknowledge American aid publicly.[23] Thus, even before his visit, Nehru expressed appreciation in parliament for American aid.[24] In Washington, he reiterated to the press that the assistance had been "very helpful." When asked what the US could do to help India, he mentioned aid, particularly loans. To address concerns about Indian socialism that were often expressed on Capitol Hill, Nehru also told American business leaders that India's economic policy was based not on dogma, but on pragmatism.[25]

No More "You're with Us or against Us"

Nehru's visit helped highlight an aspect of the relationship that had been improving over the previous few months: the increased understanding of, if not convergence with, the other government's foreign policy approach. This improvement, which would continue for the rest of the Eisenhower administration, had a salutary effect on the relationship.

For one, there was greater tolerance on the part of Eisenhower for what he called neutralism and Nehru called nonalignment. This meant less criticism and more acceptance of Delhi's diversified portfolio of partners as it pursued relationships with both Moscow and Washington. There was a more sophisticated understanding of nonalignment, with American assessments seeing it as a strategy that countries perceived as best serving their interests rather than as a rigid ideology.[26] In language that Nehru could have used, Eisenhower publicly noted that *neutrality* did not necessarily mean neutral between right or wrong, and was largely a desire not to get entangled in a military alliance. He added that the US had been neutral for 150 years.[27] Later in his second term, he would indeed go as far as saying that India was wise to be nonaligned.[28]

Dulles also redefined his view on neutralism. Both Nixon and he initially publicly contradicted Eisenhower. The secretary of state had said that neutralism was immoral, and, in Asia, Nixon criticized the concept in general and India in particular. But Dulles subsequently declined to cite